‘Since the liberation of Bangladesh, the R&AW had practiced this policy,’ Vibhas told me. ‘The setback of 1975 was enough to trigger a major policy shift. The event taught a basic lesson to the political decision makers that the neighbour’s complex problems couldn’t be resolved with fledgling diplomats at the helm of affairs. In December 1983, Er-shad declared himself president and Indian intelligence officers knew the battle was going to be long and treacherous.’

In July 1984, just months before her assassination in October 1984, Prime Minister Indira Gandhi decided—during the South Asian Regional Co-operation (SARC) meeting in the Maldives—to intensify operational activities with India’s immediate neighbours including Bangladesh. India also convinced the leaders of other countries to convene the next meeting in Dhaka towards the end of 1985. After Rajiv Gandhi took over as prime minister of India, he made it clear in his first public statement in January 1985 that friendlier relations with the neighbouring countries would be the government’s top priority. Gandhi visited Dhaka on 2 June 1985 after it was ravaged by a massive cyclone. The trip helped cement certain visible rifts between the two nations and Gandhi assured Ershad of India’s help in rebuilding the cyclone-hit regions. Rajiv Gandhi and Ershad had two more meetings in 1985. In October, they met in the Bahamas and the talks were primarily focused on the long-standing problem of Ganga water shortages. They agreed to set up a ministerial level task force to discuss the issue and in November 1985 and a meeting was duly held in New Delhi. Gandhi and Ershad met again in December 1985 in Dhaka to discuss the bilateral relationship. A statement issued by the MEA at the time said: